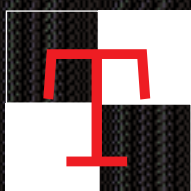


A Game of Chess



he technology market is perhaps the goriest of them all. With companies fighting tooth and nail to catch your eye and releasing products on a monthly basis, one thing's for sure—life's never boring. Most of us don't even realise the amount of research and development and planning that goes into releasing a new model of even a humble flash drive, let alone the mammoth task of developing and launching a new processor architecture, graphics card, motherboard, monitor, hard drive, etc.

Someone here at *Digit* likened it to a battle of chess grandmasters—there's the opening move (announcing the release dates of the product); the countering of every attack (keeping an eye on what your competition is doing); carefully planning your future moves even before your opponent makes his (market research, etc.); and finally, as soon as you can, move in for the kill... and checkmate!

Products are released with a full frontal attack, moving like a castle; intelligently side-stepping diagonally like a bishop; castling to protect their kings when threatened; all in the attempt to stymie the opponent and win the battle. All of this only lasts for few months, and then the battle is reset as easily as a chessboard can

be, and a new generation of products battle it out all over again.

We'd like to think of our annual Zero1 Awards as the culmination of the year's tournaments, and the felicitation of the winners as the crowning of a grandmaster—champion of the world! Like in chess, you shouldn't make the mistake of thinking of the products we've tested in terms of winners and losers. Whether the reigning champions prevail, or lose out to newer releases, you can bet your life that companies will take the necessary measures to come back and win whatever they may have lost this year.

For example, our processor segment sees Intel outplay AMD, winning the game in very few moves indeed. Their Core architecture will remain their cash cow for some time on, and the Penryn only promises more of the same. AMD, meanwhile, countered with their true-quad cores, and are defending pretty well. The graphics card segment saw a similar story with NVIDIA and ATI (AMD again), with NVIDIA winning this round of the tournament.

In this, the first of our two part Zero1 coverage, we've divided products into 16 categories, read on to find out which products were the grandmasters of 2007. Keep a look out next month as well, where we'll cover the felicitation ceremony and announce a few more awards.

In the pages that follow, you will find products that can be considered the cream of the crop, battling it out for supremacy, and more importantly, the coveted Digit Zero1 Award

